interpretation more than anyone since Einstein but also discovering a profound new truth about nature in the process. “Nonlocality, I think, was [Bell’s] great discovery,” said Bertlmann. “I think it [is] one of the greatest discoveries in the last century, that there is nonlocality in nature.” Yet Bell, a modest man, did not receive the recognition and accolades he deserved in his lifetime for his work. Several years before Bell’s death, he and Bertlmann were having tea in the outdoor cafeteria at CERN, enjoying the views of the Alps and the Jura in the afternoon sun, when Bertlmann mentioned that he thought Bell had been sold short. “I just suddenly said to him, John, I think you deserve the Nobel Prize,” Bertlmann recalled. “He was surprised, and asked ‘Why?’ [I said] because of Bell’s theorem!” Bell pointed out that the experimental tests of his theorem had not shown any deviation from quantum physics, which was not worthy of a Nobel Prize. And besides, he added, “I don’t think I deserve it because I stick to Nobel’s original rules, and I do not see how my inequalities could contribute to the benefit of mankind.” (Alfred Nobel had originally stipulated that the prizes were to be given to people who had contributed most to the benefit of humanity in the previous year through work in their field.) Bertlmann protested, “I replied, no I don’t agree. I think it is nonlocality [that is worthy of the prize].… Then on the one hand he was pleased, but on the other hand, he was saying, a bit disappointed and sadly, ‘Who cares about this nonlocality?’… So he felt that the community did not realize this enough, or did not appreciate this enough. I mean it was clear at CERN, he was highly appreciated there as a particle physicist. But his work in quantum physics was not appreciated.” Unbeknownst to Bell, he was shortlisted for the Nobel Prize the year before he died and might well have won it had he lived longer—but the Nobel Prize isn’t awarded posthumously (another stipulation of Alfred Nobel’s will).

Yet Bell’s legacy was assured, though he did not live to see it. “The great boom came in the 90s with quantum information,” said Bertlmann. “It is a new community now, which was not there in the 80s.… So actually he could not see the fruits of his work.” Bell, through his profound physical insights and his pellucid, urgent prose, had managed to shift the mindset of physics as a whole and had unintentionally conjured the entirely new field of quantum information processing out of thin air at the same time. And his contributions to “quantum engineering”—his work on particle physics and